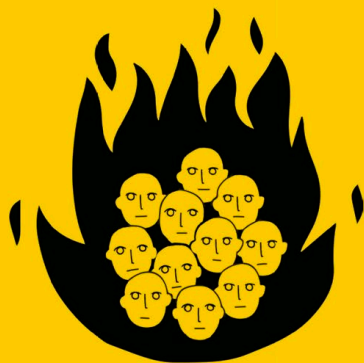




THOU SHALT NOT SUFFER A WITCH TO LIVE

THE SALEM WITCH TRIALS (1692)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Due process

BEFORE

1486 The German treatise *Malleus Maleficarum* (*The Hammer of Witches*) advises using torture to get confessions and advocates the death penalty for those convicted.

1581–1593 The Trier Witch Trials in Germany, one of the largest witch trials in Europe, sees some 368 people executed.

1662 At a witch trial in Bury St. Edmunds, England, spectral evidence is ruled as admissible.

AFTER

1697 Massachusetts governor William Stoughton calls for a day of prayer and atonement for events in Salem.

1711 Massachusetts reverses 22 verdicts of the convicted. (The remaining nine are exonerated in 1957, and the state officially apologizes for the trials.)

Mass hysteria leads to the imprisonment of **more than 200 suspected witches** in Salem.



Trials begin in May 1692 with the use of **spectral evidence** (from dreams or visions), resulting in **19 people** being found guilty and **put to death**.



Only three further people are found guilty, and by May 1693, all **remaining prisoners are released**.



After local governor William Phips's wife is **questioned over witchcraft**, he instigates a court that **does not allow spectral evidence**.



In January 1697, Judge Samuel Sewall makes a **public apology** for the trials.

The Devil and his recruitment of witches had long been perceived as a threat across Europe. Between 1300 and the end of the 1600s, tens of thousands of people (mostly women) were put to death as witches across the region, often confessing to their “crime” after sustained torture. Although they began many years after the

witch panic had swept Europe, the trials in Salem, Massachusetts, in 1692 saw 19 people hanged and more than 200 accused in a case of mass hysteria. The trials rested on similar issues to those of the past: scapegoating vulnerable people.

When a local minister's daughters began having fainting fits and acting strangely, it seemed